individual rights is a sacred duty of the government. This includes the inalienable right of every individual to their privacy.

The information that had been leaked had become the basis of unfounded and defamatory speculation that violated his and his group's privacy rights. As Ratan lamented in an interview, he had not objected to the tapes being used to establish any wrongdoing but was opposed to their being used for slandering. He said: 'The content needs to be held for prosecution purposes and not to be misused, and certainly not to go out to have a field day with.'

In the interview, he expressed the hope that the government would 'stop this sort of Banana Republic kind of attack on whoever one chooses to attack on a basis unsubstantiated even before the person [can exercise] a very Indian right—namely to be considered innocent until found guilty in a court of law'.

What disquieted Ratan even more was the 'trial by media' that followed the leak. In his case, as he asserted in a letter he sent to the head of a media group, he was '"charged and convicted" by the media on the basis of hearsay, rumours and innuendos'.

On 26 November 2010, Ratan appealed to then Prime Minister Manmohan Singh to step in to protect his rights and safeguard rule of law in the country. He wrote: 'The recent media blitz based on recordings undertaken by the Income Tax and the "trial by media," which has chosen to disseminate misleading information, implicate, accuse and even convict individuals in total abuse of every citizen's right to be considered innocent until proven guilty by a court of law, should be a concern to all of us.' Importantly, Ratan underscored the necessity of enquiring into how 'government property in the form of these taped conversations have not been secure[d] for the purpose it was intended but instead have become a tool in the hands of vested interests'.

He also requested that 'the Government should initiate a public enquiry into the implementation of Government policy in the telecom sector since 1999 and to ensure that this fast moving sector can be allowed to grow to its true potential on a level playing field for all rather than protected growth of a few'.

On the same day, he raised similar concerns in a letter to Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee: 'Conversations relating to the telecom sector which relate to TTSL, are all concerned with seeking redressal from the DoT to inconsistencies in policies and advocating a level playing field,